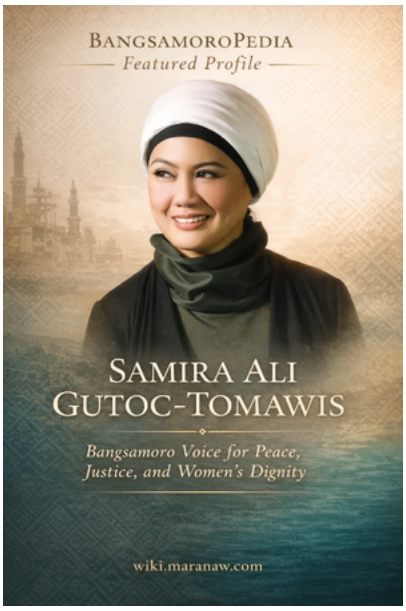
Samira Ali Gutoc

Samira Ali Gutoc-Tomawis (born 19 December 1974) is a Maranao civic leader, journalist, and human rights advocate whose work centers on peace education, gender equality, and the rights of internally displaced persons in conflict-affected Mindanao. Her legacy is defined by a fierce commitment to bringing Bangsamoro voices into national politics and ensuring that women shape, not merely benefit from, peace processes. From the halls of the Bangsamoro Transition Commission to her grassroots work with evacuees from the Marawi siege, Gutoc has carved a path that integrates Islamic principles with democratic governance and universal human rights standards.

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Samira Ali Gutoc-Tomawis



Born	19 December 1974
Birthplace	Jeddah, Saudi Arabia
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Residence	Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Father	Ambassador Candidato B. Gutoc (rahimahullah)
Mother	Bae Tomanina Ali
Spouse	Engr. Abdul Maomit Tomawis
Children	Amir
Occupation	Civic leader, journalist, lawyer, women's rights advocate
Known for	Bangsamoro peace advocacy, IDP rights, Marawi rehabilitation

Early Life and Family

Samira Ali Gutoc was born on 19 December 1974 in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, where her father, Ambassador **Candidato Gutoc** (rahimahullah), served as a career diplomatic officer who eventually rose to the rank of Philippine Ambassador to Saudi Arabia.<ref name="gutoc_wiki">Wikipedia, Samira Ali Gutoc</ref> Her mother, Bae Tomanina Ali, is a real property developer. The family's time in the Middle East during Samira's childhood profoundly shaped her worldview and instilled in her a commitment to bridge Muslim and Western perspectives on governance and human rights.

Gutoc is a descendant of Datu Timbul Ali of Balo-i, Lanao del Norte, an important lineage within Maranao leadership circles. She comes of age within a family that valued public service and cross-cultural dialogue, trajectories she would later build upon through her own activism.

Education

Gutoc's academic journey reflects a deliberate arc from communications and international relations into law and Islamic studies, equipping her for her complex role as a bridge-builder in peace processes.

- **Bachelor of Arts in Broadcast Communication**: University of the Philippines Diliman (UP Diliman). She made her mark here as the first female president of the UP Muslim Students Association, breaking ground in a male-dominated student leadership structure.<ref name="pcid">Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy</ref>
- **Master in International Studies**: UP Diliman (2001)
- **Bachelor of Laws**: Arellano University School of Law (2006)
- **Fellowship**: Oxford Center for Islamic Studies, United Kingdom (2003)

Career and Institutional Roles

Journalism and Media

Gutoc began her professional life as a journalist, using her platform to amplify marginalized voices. She wrote the column "A Girl From Marawi" for *The Philippine Business and News*, later expanding her media presence with "My, My, My Marawi" in *MindaViews*.<ref name="gutoc_wiki" /> Her journalism work, grounded in lived experience and rigorous reporting, distinguished her as a credible voice on Mindanao's complexities.

In 2024, she expanded her media footprint as anchor of *The Voice and The Voiceless* at Filipinos World, a program produced in partnership with *The Manila Times*. Through her columns and broadcasts, she maintains a consistent beat on Marawi reconstruction and the plight of evacuees, refusing to let the community's struggles fade from public memory.

Regional Governance (ARMM Assembly)

In May 2012, President Benigno Aquino III appointed Gutoc as one of 27 officer-in-charge (OIC) members of the 7th Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM) Regional Legislative Assembly, representing the women's sector.<ref name="gutoc_wiki" /> She served in this capacity until the 2013 elections. During her tenure, she

advocated for gender-responsive policies and amplified women's concerns in regional deliberations, laying groundwork for later work on gender mainstreaming in the Bangsamoro peace process.

Banking and Finance

From 2008 to 2012, Gutoc served as a director of the Al-Amanah Islamic Investment Bank of the Philippines, one of the country's pioneering Islamic financial institutions.<ref name="peoplaid">PeoPlaid, Samira Gutoc Biography</ref> This role exposed her to the intersection of Islamic finance and development, further deepening her understanding of faith-based approaches to economic empowerment in Muslim communities.

The Bangsamoro Transition Commission and Legislative Impact

Gutoc's most consequential institutional role came in February 2017, when President Rodrigo Duterte appointed her as one of 21 members of the Bangsamoro Transition Commission (BTC), tasked with drafting the enabling law for the peace agreement between the Philippine government and the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF).<ref name="gutoc_wiki" /> The resulting Bangsamoro Organic Law (RA 11054), passed in 2018, established the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM), a historic step toward addressing decades of conflict.

Within the BTC, Gutoc emerged as a champion of gender and development (GAD) mainstreaming. She pushed for mechanisms that would ensure women's meaningful participation in the new Bangsamoro Parliament and Cabinet, not as tokenistic representation but as architects of governance. Her advocacy directly contributed to the BOL's provision for reserved seats for women in Bangsamoro institutions, institutionalizing gender considerations in peace governance.

However, Gutoc's tenure was cut short by principle. On 29 May 2017, she resigned from the BTC in protest of three developments: the government's handling of the Battle of Marawi, the declaration of Martial Law in Mindanao, and a deeply offensive joke made by President Duterte, in which he stated he would take personal blame for soldiers who committed rape during martial law.<ref name="gutoc_resign">Rappler, Bangsamoro member resigns over Duterte rape joke, martial law</ref> She chose conscience over position, a decision that reverberated across civil society and underscored her unwavering commitment to women's dignity.

Marawi and Humanitarian Response

The Battle of Marawi (2017) became the defining crisis of Gutoc's advocacy. As a Marawi resident, she witnessed firsthand the siege that displaced over 350,000 people and left much of the city in ruins.

Ranao Rescue Team

During the siege itself, Gutoc helped establish the Ranao Rescue Team, a volunteer organization that mobilized to provide relief assistance, evacuation support, and legal aid to civilians caught in the crossfire.<ref name="gutoc_wiki" /> Operating under dangerous conditions, the team became a lifeline for families separated by conflict. The group's work was documented by major international outlets including the Wall Street Journal, Washington Post, New York Times, and Al Jazeera, bringing global attention to the humanitarian dimensions of the crisis.

Legislative Advocacy for Marawi Rehabilitation

Gutoc has maintained relentless legislative focus on Marawi's recovery. Her priorities include:

- **Marawi Siege Victims Compensation Act**: She championed this legislation, which was eventually signed as RA 11696 in 2022, providing financial recompense to residents who lost private property during the siege. Gutoc has continued to press for full and transparent implementation of the law.
- **Lake Lanao Development Authority**: Gutoc proposed creation of a dedicated authority to manage Lake Lanao, a critical natural and cultural resource for the Maranao people. She argues that local participation in resource management is essential to both environmental sustainability and cultural preservation.
- **Internally Displaced Persons (IDP) Rights Framework**: Through her organization Ako Bakwit, Inc., co-founded in 2020 with Nazh-Far Mariwa Berganio, Gutoc has championed a national framework to protect the rights of evacuees, whether displaced by conflict or natural disaster. "Bakwit" (evacuee) is the Maranao term for internally displaced person, and the organization has worked to institutionalize government support and legal protection for this vulnerable population.<ref name="gutoc_wiki" />
- **Audit and Transparency of Marawi Funds**: She has repeatedly called for independent audits of rehabilitation budgets to prevent corruption and ensure that resources reach affected communities rather than disappearing into bureaucratic channels.
- **Mental Health and Psychosocial Support**: Beyond infrastructure, Gutoc argues that rehabilitation must address the psychological and spiritual trauma of displacement. She has proposed legislation for trauma-informed mental health services and culturally sensitive healing programs.

National Political Campaigns

Gutoc has sought national office twice, attempting to bring Bangsamoro perspectives into the Philippine Senate.

2019 Senate Campaign (Otso Diretso)

In October 2018, Gutoc announced her candidacy for senator under the Otso Diretso coalition, a Liberal Party-led opposition slate mobilized against the Duterte administration.<ref name="gutoc_wiki" /> Her platform centered on peace education, women's and Muslims' rights, opposition to the lowering of the minimum age of criminal responsibility, and Marawi rehabilitation. She conducted an extensive door-to-door campaign across the archipelago, personally connecting with voters in towns and provinces.

The 2019 campaign brought national visibility to Gutoc's advocacy. However, on 19 July 2019, the PNP-Criminal Investigation and Detection Group (CIDG) filed charges against Gutoc and other Otso Diretso members for sedition, cyber libel, libel, estafa, harboring a criminal, and obstruction of justice. The charges linked them to *The Real Narcolist* video series, which the PNP-CIDG claimed contained disinformation. She placed 25th in the final count, failing to secure a Senate seat.

2022 Senate Campaign (Aksyon Demokratiko)

By 2022, Gutoc sought to move beyond the opposition label. On 9 August 2021, she joined Aksyon Demokratiko, the political party founded by the late Senator Raul Roco. She admired Roco's "Agenda of Hope" and believed the party offered a constructive alternative to partisan gridlock. Running under the Isko Moreno presidential ticket,

Gutoc's platform evolved to emphasize pandemic recovery and the need for a "war against disease" while continuing her core advocacy for Bangsamoro rights and IDP protection.

She placed 39th in the 2022 senatorial count, again falling short of a Senate seat. Despite electoral setbacks, Gutoc has maintained that her role is to raise issues and shape national conversation, whether or not elected office follows.

Legislative Positions and Platform

Peace and Security

Gutoc is a vocal opponent of the Anti-Terrorism Act of 2020 (RA 11479). She led a coalition of indigenous peoples in filing one of 37 constitutional petitions before the Supreme Court challenging the law's validity.<ref name="gutoc_wiki" /> Her principal concerns are that the law's broad and vague definitions of "terrorism" enable weaponization against political critics and activists, and that extended pre-charge detention periods (up to 24 days) violate international human rights standards. Drawing on her experience in Marawi, she argues that security-first policies without due process safeguards exacerbate tensions in conflict zones.

Gutoc staunchly opposes the reimposition of capital punishment and has campaigned against lowering the minimum age of criminal responsibility, believing both measures undermine human dignity and rehabilitation.

Justice and Governance

She supports legalization of divorce in the Philippines, arguing that the absence of legal remedy traps women in abusive or failed marriages. As a former journalist, she champions the Freedom of Information (FOI) Bill to enshrine government transparency and accountability.

On governance structure, Gutoc has expressed openness to federalism as a system that could better serve regional needs, particularly in Mindanao, though she prioritizes substantive autonomy and resource allocation over formal structure.

Health and Compassion

Gutoc supports the legalization of medical marijuana for therapeutic use, particularly for patients with chronic pain and senior citizens. She explicitly opposes recreational marijuana use, framing her stance as compassionate rather than permissive.

War on Drugs and the International Criminal Court

She has been a consistent and vocal critic of the Duterte administration's anti-drug campaign, characterizing it as a "bloody" and failed policy that has resulted in thousands of killings. She supports allowing the International Criminal Court to investigate alleged extrajudicial killings in the Philippines, positioning accountability as necessary for healing and justice.

Women in Peacebuilding

Gutoc's deepest conviction is that women are not merely victims of conflict who need protection but are instead architects of sustainable peace. She is a steadfast advocate for United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325, which recognizes women's essential role in conflict prevention and resolution.

Her arguments rest on three pillars: **inclusive security**, **deconstructing stereotypes**, and **grassroots empowerment**.

Gutoc contends that national security clusters and peace commissions must integrate women and gender development leaders, not as afterthoughts but as core decision-makers. Since women and children suffer disproportionately from armed conflict, she argues, they possess unique knowledge of what sustainable peace requires.

She challenges the "patriarchal culture" that discourages Muslim women from public leadership. Through her own visibility, she demonstrates that Islam upholds gender equality and that the Quran calls women to civic participation. She has lobbied for policies mandating local government units to establish Women's Councils and has pushed for gender-sensitive reform within the Philippine National Police (PNP) and Philippine Army.

International Recognition and Advocacy

Gutoc has represented the Philippines as a speaker and advocate in over 30 countries, integrating Islamic principles with universal human rights standards and advancing the concept of "peace from within"—rooted in faith communities rather than imposed from above.

International Affiliations

- **Asian Peace Alliance**: Founded by Gutoc, this organization works to mainstream peace narratives across Asia. It is associated with the Asia-Pacific Peace Research Association (APPRA).<ref name="pcid" />
- **Asian Muslim Action Network (AMAN)**: A regular contributor to its publication *AMANAH*, Gutoc advances peace and development discourse across the region.
- **Young Moro Professionals Network (YMPN)**: As co-convenor, she has built international solidarity with organizations in Pakistan and across ASEAN, elevating Bangsamoro professional voices.

Awards and Recognition

- **Muslim 500 / World's Most Influential Muslims**: Listed by the Royal Islamic Strategic Studies Centre in Jordan (and also cited by Georgetown University sources), Gutoc is recognized as one of 500 Muslims globally shaping discourse on social issues and peace.<ref name="gutoc_wiki" />
- **N-Peace Award (2018)**: Conferred by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) for her humanitarian work in conflict-affected areas.
- **Ten Outstanding Young Men (TOYM) (2001)**: Awarded by the Junior Chamber International for leadership in socio-cultural and youth development.
- **Ten Outstanding Women in the Nation's Service (TOWNS) (2019)**: Recognition for her lifelong service to the nation.

- **Award of Service (2025)**: Conferred by the United Nations Association of the Philippines (UNAP) on UN Day for her enduring commitment to humanitarian principles.

Academic and Public Engagements

Gutoc has lectured on Islamic leadership, women in peacebuilding, and education for development at over 30 international and domestic conferences, including symposia organized by Amnesty International, UNESCO, and De La Salle University. In 2026, she served as a key panelist at the **Women Leadership Forum 2026**, discussing the intersection of women's health and global leadership. She has also participated in the **ASEAN-Japan Relations** forum in Tokyo, where she discussed regional partnerships and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific.

Through projects supported by USAID, AUSAID, and the Department of Foreign Affairs (DFA), Gutoc has worked to mainstream positive Muslim narratives in global media and popularize the Code of Muslim Personal Laws, positioning Islamic jurisprudence as compatible with development and human rights.

Personal Life and Legacy

Gutoc is married to Engineer Abdul Maomit Tomawis and has one son, Amir. She resides in Marawi City, where she has chosen to remain throughout the rehabilitation period despite the hardships, embedding herself within the community she serves.

Her work reflects a conviction that progress requires refusing false choices between Islam and democracy, between faith and gender equality, between peace and accountability. She embodies what it means to be a modern Maranao woman: rooted in tradition, fearless in demanding justice, and committed to building institutions that honor both the dignity of her people and universal human rights.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Battle of Marawi
- Marawi City
- Maranao people
- Peace Education in the Philippines
- Women in Bangsamoro Governance

Further Reading

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